A PSYCHOLOGICAL STUDY OF THE IMPACT OF CULTURAL BARRIERS ON PASTORAL COUNSELING EFFECTIVENESS IN BUGUMA CITY, NIGERIA

By

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A THESIS SUBMITTED TO THE DEPARTMENT OF PSYCHOLOGY AND BIBLICAL COUNSELING, FACULTY OF ARTS AND HUMANITIES, EL-ELYON INTERNATIONAL BIBLE COLLEGE AND SEMINARY, ABUJA, NIGERIA, IN PARTIAL FULFILMENT OF THE REQUIREMENTS FOR THE AWARD OF THE DEGREE OF DOCTOR OF PHILOSOPHY (Ph.D.) IN PSYCHOLOGY AND BIBLICAL COUNSELING

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DECLARATION

I, Ukwoma Obugheni Police, declare that this research work titled "A Psychological Study of the Impact of Cultural Barriers on Pastoral Counseling Effectiveness in Buguma City, Nigeria" is my original work. It was carried out under supervision in the Department of Psychology and Biblical Counseling, Faculty of Arts and Humanities, El-Elyon International Bible College and Seminary, Abuja, Nigeria.

All sources of literature, data and scholarly information used in this study have been duly acknowledged in the text and listed in the reference section. No part of this work has previously been submitted, in whole or in part, for the award of any other degree or diploma at this or any other institution of higher learning.

Ukwoma Obugheni Police Date: _____

CERTIFICATION

This is to certify that this thesis titled "A Psychological Study of the Impact of Cultural Barriers on Pastoral Counseling Effectiveness in Buguma City, Nigeria," submitted by Ukwoma Obugheni Police, matriculation number EIBCS2526P012, meets the regulations governing the award of the degree of Doctor of Philosophy (Ph.D.) in Psychology and Biblical Counseling of El-Elyon International Bible College and Seminary, Abuja, Nigeria, and is approved for its contribution to knowledge and literary presentation.

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Chairman, Research Committee Date: _____

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Research Supervisor: Dr Solapat Bamidele Date: _____

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Head of Department, Psychology and Biblical Counseling Date: _____

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Academic Dean Date: _____

DEDICATION

This work is dedicated to God Almighty, for the gift of life, divine sustenance and unwavering grace throughout this academic journey, and for 51 years of His faithfulness.

It is also dedicated to my parents, Mr Ukwoma Police and Mrs Toli Ukwoma, whose sacrifices laid the foundation for my education, and to my beloved nuclear family, whose endless patience, prayers and support provided the sanctuary needed to bring this doctoral research to fruition.

Finally, it is dedicated to my esteemed Supervisor, Dr Solapat Bamidele, on his 51st birthday: a father, pastor and mentor to many, whose guidance made this work possible.

ABSTRACT

This study examined the impact of cultural barriers on pastoral counseling effectiveness in Buguma City, headquarters of Asari-Toru Local Government Area, Rivers State, Nigeria. Buguma is a major Kalabari settlement of 39 Polo, where pastoral care operates within a communal worldview shaped by belief in ancestral influence and Owuamapu (water-deity worship), respect for elders, and the authority of the Amanyanabo and Council of Chiefs. The study was anchored on Multicultural Counseling Theory, African Psychology, Social Cognitive Theory and Stigma Theory. Each theory was linked to specific study variables: cultural beliefs and practices, cultural stigma, preference for tradition, language differences, and strategies to mitigate the barriers, with pastoral counseling effectiveness as the outcome.

A descriptive cross-sectional correlational survey was adopted. The estimated population was 5,000 (102 lead and assistant pastors and 4,898 adult members who had received counseling in the preceding 12 months) across 51 PFN- and CAN-affiliated churches. The Taro Yamane formula, $n = N / [1 + N(e)^2]$, with N = 5,000 and e = 0.05, gave 370.4, taken as 370; adding 10 percent (37) for anticipated non-response gave 407. Multi-stage sampling was used: all 51 churches identified by geo-mapping, a census of all 102 pastors, and proportionate stratified random selection of 305 members. The instrument was the researcher-developed Cultural Barriers and Pastoral Counseling Effectiveness Questionnaire (CBPCEQ), with 38 items in seven sections and a 5-point scale. All 407 questionnaires were returned complete (100% return rate) because they were administered face to face and collected on the spot; this describes returns among those who accepted a questionnaire, not a response rate among everyone approached. Data were analysed with frequencies, percentages, means, standard deviations, Pearson and Spearman correlations and multiple regression at the 0.05 level of significance.

All four cultural barriers were endorsed: language differences (M = 4.12, SD = 0.35), cultural stigma (M = 4.07, SD = 0.30), preference for tradition (M = 3.63, SD = 0.28) and cultural beliefs and practices (M = 3.21, SD = 0.27), the weakest. Pastoral counseling was rated effective (M = 4.15, SD = 0.29; at least 98.5% agreement on every item). Strategies to mitigate the barriers received the highest agreement (M = 4.24, SD = 0.40), with training pastors in Kalabari language and culture ranked first (M = 4.29). Correlations with effectiveness were small and positive: cultural beliefs and practices ($r = .11$, $p = .030$; $\rho = .09$, $p = .061$), cultural stigma ($r = .12$, $p = .013$; $\rho = .09$, $p = .081$), preference for tradition ($r = .18$; $\rho = .19$; both $p < .001$), language differences ($r = .28$; $\rho = .35$; both $p < .001$) and strategies ($r = .24$; $\rho = .34$; both $p < .001$). The regression model was significant, $F(5, 401) = 10.95$, $p < .001$, $R = .347$, $R^2 = .120$, adjusted $R^2 = .109$, Durbin-Watson = 1.92, with no multicollinearity (tolerance .77 to .93; VIF 1.07 to 1.30). Only language differences ($\beta = .20$, $p < .001$) and strategies ($\beta = .18$, $p < .001$) were independent predictors.

The positive direction of the relationships is opposite to the theoretical expectation that stronger barriers lower effectiveness. It is explained by the fact that every respondent had already received counseling, that scores clustered at the agreement end of the scale, and that agreement tendency or social desirability may have contributed. Two scales had low reliability (cultural beliefs and practices, $\alpha = .24$; preference for tradition, $\alpha = .53$), so findings on these two constructs are less secure; a sensitivity analysis with shortened scales left the main conclusions unchanged. The study recommends: (1) Kalabari language and cultural-competence training for pastors; (2) community psychoeducation to reduce stigma and a guarantee of confidentiality; (3) culturally consistent involvement of family elders as

partners; (4) referral networks between pastoral and clinical services; and (5) combining biblical principles with cultural understanding.

Keywords: Cultural barriers, pastoral counseling effectiveness, Kalabari, language barrier, stigma, Buguma City, CBPCEQ, pastoral training

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